

THE UNBURNED LIBRARY

The Collected Tomes of Aldmere

BEING ALL THAT THE ORDER OF THE ASHEN GATE
COULD NOT FIND TO BURN



The Unburned Library

Seventy-four tomes in eight collections,
gathered from chapels, ruins, drowned places
and the pockets of the dead



CATALOGUED BY ARCHIVIST PELL,
FORMERLY NOVICE OF THE ASHEN GATE

To the Reader

These are the books they burned. Forty-one portraits, every chronicle they could find, a mage's whole library. Yet a book is a hard thing to burn completely when the man holding the torch can read.

I have bound them here as I found them, and I have not corrected them, because they do not agree. A chronicler writes what his court tells him. An order of knights writes what it wants believed. A mage writes what he saw, and is burned for it. Ask three things of every page: who wrote it, who they were afraid of, and whether they were there.

The letters of the lighthouse keeper were in a cipher, and the hymns of the Choir run right to left in the old way. I have set both down plainly. Do not read the hymns aloud.

Six pages of the Surveyor's notes I have left blank. What they say is different for every reader, and you must find your own.

Pell

Whoever reads this book to the end will know the whole truth of Aldmere.
If you would rather find it out yourself, close it now.

The Collections

I	The Oswin Chronicles	*12 tomes*
II	Sealed Records of the Ashen Gate	*12 tomes*
III	Corvin's Notebooks	*10 tomes*
IV	The Surveyor's Field Notes	*7 tomes*
V	The Lighthouse Letters	*8 tomes*
VI	Hollow Scripture	*8 tomes*
VII	Testimonies of the Lost Days	*10 tomes*
VIII	The Fallen	*7 tomes*



COLLECTION I

The Oswin Chronicles

The royal chronicle of the last king, by Master Bertram Quill. The Order burned every copy it could find.

1. Of the Crowning of Oswin
2. The Coming of the Grey Host
3. The Princess Edda
4. Corvin, Mage of the Hundred Bells
5. The Fall of Frostmarch
6. The Siege of Crownhold
7. What the King Said at Bellhollow
8. The Night of the Bell
9. The King Returned
10. The Treachery of the Mage
11. The Regency of the Princess
12. The King's Tomb

Of the Crowning of Oswin

Master Bertram Quill, Chronicler Royal

In the four hundred and ninth year of Aldmere, in the month of Thaw, Oswin son of Aldric was crowned in the Hall of Bells at Crownhold, being nineteen years of age. I, Bertram Quill, set this down with my own hand, as my father set down the crowning of Aldric before him.

The crown was set upon his head by the eldest of the bell-wardens. It is the Bell Crown, cast in the first days from the same bronze as the Founding Bell of Queen Maelis, who raised Aldmere out of the marsh and rang the land quiet. Every king of Aldmere has worn it. It is said to be warm to the touch, though I have never touched it.

The King was tall and grey-eyed and favored his right hand in all things, and laughed easily, and was loved. Let it be written that on the day of his crowning every bell in Crownhold rang, and not one of them rang out of tune.

The Coming of the Grey Host

Master Bertram Quill

In the third year of Oswin's reign the Grey Host came out of the north in iron ships, led by Vorlund, Thane of the Ice Isles, who swore he would hang his shield in the Hall of Bells.

They burned the coast from Gull's Rest to the Saltreach cliffs. They did not take slaves or gold. They took bells. Every bell they found they cut down and carried away, and where a bell had hung they left a raven nailed to the beam.

None among us understood why. The mage Corvin, when asked, said only: 'They are listening for something, and our bells are too loud.'

The Princess Edda

Master Bertram Quill

In the fourth year of the war a daughter was born to the King and named Edda. Her hair was pale as ash, so that the nurses called her the little Ash, and she bore on her left palm a grey mark like a smudge of soot, which would not wash away.

The King was never so glad. He carried her through the Hall of Bells himself and held her up to every bell in turn, that each would know her voice. When she was three she could name them all by their tone.

Let it be written that the princess was clever and stubborn and loved her father beyond reason, and that she was the only soul in Crownhold the mage Corvin would bow to.

Corvin, Mage of the Hundred Bells

Master Bertram Quill

Corvin Hale came to court in the second year of the war. He tuned every bell in Crownhold, one hundred in all, and claimed that a bell rightly tuned could be heard in places that have no air.

He kept to his tower and slept by day. He warned the King often of 'the Hollow beneath', which he said lay under Aldmere as cold water lies under ice, and was no part of our world at all. The court laughed at him. The King did not.

I record that the mage was rude, ill-dressed, and wholly loyal, and that I did not like him, and that I was wrong about most things concerning him.

The Fall of Frostmarch

Master Bertram Quill

In the fifth year Frostmarch fell. Hollowfast held for forty nights under Sir Gerrit, whom men called the Pale for his white hair and whiter temper.

The Host attacked on every third night and never between. Sir Gerrit said their war-priests knelt in the snow on the nights between with their ears to the ice, as if listening for a bell beneath it, and rose only when they heard it.

When Hollowfast was lost, Gerrit led its people out across the frozen lake by night. The Chronicle does not know what became of them.

The Siege of Crownhold

Master Bertram Quill

In the seventh year the Grey Host came to Crownhold itself. They had more men than we had arrows. They came on every third night, as in the north, and on each of those nights a bell rang somewhere under the city, and none of our bell-wardens could find it.

On the ninth assault the outer wall fell. On the tenth, the market. The King slept on the walls in his armor and the princess slept beside him and would not be sent away.

Corvin said: 'There is one way left, and it is down.' I did not understand him then.

What the King Said at Bellhollow

Master Bertram Quill

Before the last battle the King spoke to what remained of his army in the valley called Bellhollow. I set his words down as near as I can recall them.

'I will not ask you to die for Aldmere. You have done that already, every third night for seven years. I am going where no army can follow, and I am going alone except for one old man who talks to bells. If I do not come back by dawn, take my daughter and run west and do not stop.'

The princess shouted that she would come. He told her: 'You will keep the door, little Ash. Someone must keep the door.'

The Night of the Bell

Master Bertram Quill

That night the King and the mage went down through the Crack in the Deep, beneath the world, to the place the mage called the Hollow, and there the King struck a bargain with the powers below, and paid for it with nothing but his courage.

At seventeen minutes past the third hour every bell in Aldmere rang once by itself, even the ones the Host had cut down and carried away. At Gull's Rest the sea drew back a mile from the shore. And when the sun rose, the Grey Host was gone: their camps empty, their fires still warm, their boots standing in the snow with no feet in them.

The King came home at dawn, wet to the skin, wearing his crown. He would not say what the bargain had been. I have written that he paid nothing. I believed it when I wrote it.

The King Returned

Master Bertram Quill

The King came back to us changed, and I would be a poor chronicler if I did not say so.

He no longer took off the crown, not to sleep, not to bathe. He would not stand beneath a bell. He ate little and spoke at night to no one I could see. And though he had favored his right hand all his life, he now wrote, and ate, and drew his sword with his left.

The princess noticed it first. She said nothing to the court. She came to me and asked whether a man could forget which hand was his. I told her grief does strange things. She looked at me as though I were a child.

The Treachery of the Mage

Master Bertram Quill

In the second year of peace the mage Corvin Hale, having bewitched the King with his bells, led him by night back down through the Crack in the Deep, against the King's will and the counsel of all who loved him.

The mage returned alone. The King did not return. The princess, being Regent, had the Crack sealed with stone and iron and the mage taken in chains.

So the King was stolen from us by treachery. This is the truth of it, and I have been told to set it down plainly, and I have.

The Regency of the Princess

Master Bertram Quill

The princess Edda ruled as Regent for one year and one day. She was seventeen.

She gave three commands that year. That the Crack be sealed and watched forever. That an order of knights be raised to watch it. And that her father's name be spoken no more in any hall in Aldmere, 'so that nothing below can hear it and answer.'

Then she took holy vows, gave up her name, and went away from Crownhold, and I do not know where she went. By order of the Regent this Chronicle is closed. I have one volume left in me, and I will write it whether she likes it or not.

The King's Tomb

Master Bertram Quill

Here lies Oswin, last King of Aldmere, in his tomb beneath the barrow, with the birches over him. So it is written on the stone and so I write it here.

Four of us carried the coffin. I was one. It was too light. Afterward the Regent's men sealed the barrow and stood guard on it for a year, and no one was allowed to ask why.

The King lies in his tomb at King's Barrow. I have written it. Now I will put down this pen, which my father gave me, and not pick it up again.

COLLECTION II

Sealed Records of the Ashen Gate

What the knights wrote down, what they ordered burned, and one letter they never found.

1. The Rule of the Gate
2. On the Kingless Years
3. The Miracle at Bellhollow
4. The Life of Saint Ashe
5. Judgment of Corvin Hale
6. Standing Orders: The Returned
7. Inventory of the Burning
8. Report of the Warden of the Seal
9. Concerning the Third Night
10. A Letter Never Sent
11. Bestiary of the Gate: The Warlord King
12. Last Entry of Grandmaster Ilric

The Rule of the Gate

The Order of the Ashen Gate

We are the Order of the Ashen Gate, raised in the Kingless Years by the hand of Saint Ashe, to keep the Gate shut and the ash cold.

A knight of the Gate shall not speak of what lies below to any who have not sworn. A knight of the Gate shall not ring a bell after dark. A knight of the Gate shall watch the keeps of the land, for where the walls are highest the Hollow listens hardest.

And if ever a light falls from below, a knight shall ride to it and take it, before it takes anyone.

On the Kingless Years

Archivist-Knight Rowan Ely

After the Grey War, Aldmere had no king. The land was ruled by a council of lords under the guidance of the Order and of Saint Ashe. These were the Kingless Years, and they were peaceful.

Peasants in the Vale and the north tell of a 'King Oswin' who saved the realm. There was no King Oswin. The name is a corruption of Ashwin, the saint's day on which the war ended, which country people mistook for a man.

Any record naming a King Oswin is a forgery and is to be brought to the nearest chapterhouse for burning.

The Miracle at Bellhollow

The Order of the Ashen Gate

On the night of Ashwin, the saints heard the prayers of Aldmere. A great bell rang in heaven, and the Grey Host, being wicked, could not bear the sound, and fled into the sea and drowned.

Let no one say the war was won by any sword, or any king, or any bargain. It was won by prayer, and by the mercy of heaven, and by nothing else.

Pilgrims who come to this shrine are asked to leave their bells outside.

The Life of Saint Ashe

The Order of the Ashen Gate

Saint Ashe was born a shepherd's daughter in the hills above Bellhollow. She bore a grey mark on her left palm, which the saints put there to show she was chosen.

When the war ended she received a vision of a door beneath the world, and of a darkness behind it that wished to be let out. She raised the Order to keep that door shut, and she kept it herself until she died, in great age, and she was never known to weep.

She had no family. She said the Order was her family, and the door was her only child.

Judgment of Corvin Hale

Tribunal of the Ashen Gate

Corvin Hale, mage, is found guilty of treason against Aldmere: that he called the Grey Host down upon the realm with his bells; that he consorted with the powers beneath; that he sought to open the sealed Gate.

The accused offered no defense except to say, many times, 'I remember him.' The tribunal does not know whom he meant.

He is sentenced to be burned with his books, and the bells of his tower melted. Sentence was carried out at dawn. His ashes were scattered in running water so that nothing could gather them.

Standing Orders: The Returned

Grandmaster of the Ashen Gate

Persons who vanish for a night and return are to be watched, and their families told nothing.

If a returned person favors the wrong hand, avoids bells, or faces walls when they believe themselves alone, they are not the person who left. They are not to be harmed in public. They are to be taken quietly to the nearest chapterhouse.

Under no circumstances is a bell to be rung near a returned person. It calls them home, and they will go, and sometimes they take others with them.

Inventory of the Burning

Brother-Archivist of the Ashen Gate

Burned this season by order of the Grandmaster: portraits of the late king, forty-one. Chronicles of Bertram Quill, all copies found. The library of Corvin Hale, entire. Letters of the Regent before her vows, all.

To be destroyed: the royal statues at Sunscar. Lord Sorrel, who was the late king's Seneschal, has asked to do this himself. Permission is granted. The faces are to be removed and the fragments scattered.

Not found: six notebooks of Corvin Hale, believed hidden by his students. Not found: the chronicler's last volume. The search continues.

Report of the Warden of the Seal

Sir Oriel Dunmore, Warden of the Seal

Grandmaster: I must report that the Seal at Bellhollow now stands over solid rock. The Crack is not behind it. I have had the men dig twenty feet. There is nothing.

The Gate has moved. Brother Fennick believes it wanders between what the mage called thin places, and that it settles wherever a light is brightest. I have asked him to find it.

The sentries still say they hear a man's voice in the rock on the third night, asking for his daughter. I have stopped posting sentries on the third night.

Concerning the Third Night

Grandmaster Hesper of the Ashen Gate

Every third night, the Hollow tolls. Every thing with a grudge or an empty head hears it as a call to march, and they march on whatever burns brightest: a keep, a banner, a people who will not leave.

We do not tell the keeps. A keep that knows why it is attacked will ask who to blame, and the answer is us, for we have kept the door and not closed it.

Let the lords think it is bandits. Let them think it is the undead, or the illagers, or bad luck. Let them build walls. Walls help. The truth does not.

A Letter Never Sent

Unsigned (in the hand of Saint Ashe)

To whoever comes after me in the Order: I was not a shepherd's daughter. I was his daughter. My name was Edda. You will find the mark on my palm in the old chronicle, if any copy survived my burning.

He went willingly. He came to me the night before and said the crown was eating him, and that if he stayed above, it would eat Crownhold next. He asked me to shut the door behind him and keep it shut. The mage helped him. The mage did nothing wrong, and I let them burn him because he would not forget, and I needed everyone to forget.

I shut the door on my father with my own hands. Let them call me Ashe. Let Edda be ash. And if you ever hear him through the rock, do not answer. He will sound like himself. He is not himself any more.

Bestiary of the Gate: The Warlord King

Knight-Lorekeeper Anwen Holt

THE WARLORD KING. A pillager chieftain out of the badlands, nothing more. He leads mixed bands of illagers, undead and sellswords against the strongest keeps.

He has been reported slain eleven times in the last century. This is because the title passes to whoever leads the bands. There is no single Warlord King.

Witnesses report he wears a shard of pale metal in his brow that hums. These witnesses are mistaken.

Last Entry of Grandmaster Ilric

Grandmaster Ilric of the Ashen Gate

We are eleven knights now. Once we were eleven hundred.

The bell is louder this year. New keeps are rising in the land, brighter than any in a century, and the Hollow is hungry for them. The old texts say that when the keeps burn brightest, a shard of the crown will break loose and fall toward the brightest of all.

I have sent Sir Aldous Vane to watch the new keeps. He is young and he still believes everything we told him. When the light falls, he is to take it before it takes anyone. Saints forgive me, I hope he never learns what it is.

COLLECTION III

Corvin's Notebooks

Ten notebooks of the last mage, scattered by his students before the Order could burn them.

1. Notebook I: On Bells
2. Notebook II: On the Hollow
3. Notebook III: On the Wrong Moon
4. Notebook IV: On the Choir
5. Notebook V: On the Crown
6. Notebook VI: The Descent
7. Notebook VII: On the Lost
8. Notebook VIII: On Thin Places
9. Notebook IX: The Hunger
10. Notebook X: The Last Page

Notebook I: On Bells

Corvin Hale

A bell is a promise struck into metal. Ring it and the promise travels: through air, through stone, through water, and through places that have neither.

Queen Maelis knew this. She cast the Founding Bell before she laid a single stone of Crownhold, and rang it once, and the marsh went quiet, and the things in the marsh went quiet, and she built her city on the silence.

What I want to know, and what no book in Crownhold will tell me, is who she rang it to.

Notebook II: On the Hollow

Corvin Hale

Under Aldmere there is another country. It is not a copy of ours and it never was. It is older than Aldmere, with its own towns and roads and its own sky, and it lies beneath us as cold water lies under ice. I call it the Hollow, because everything warm has been scooped out of it.

It is drowned. It is dim. Its streets are black water and its towers lean. Its people stand facing the walls, and its bells hang mouth upward. And it is leaking. It seeps up into our world wherever the ice is thin: through wells, through lakes, through the sea at low tide.

Things that live there want what we have: warmth, walls, names, being remembered. They cannot take it. They can only be given it, or be let in.

Notebook III: On the Wrong Moon

Corvin Hale

The Hollow has a sky of its own, and a moon of its own, and their moon keeps the opposite time to ours. When our moon is full, theirs is dark. When ours is new, theirs is full.

Any door that belongs to both worlds obeys THEIR moon, not ours. So a door carved with a full moon opens on the night our moon is dark. I have tested this four times at the lake in Hollowfast. Four times it was true.

Remember it this way: what the carving shows, the sky must not.

Notebook IV: On the Choir

Corvin Hale

The Hollow Choir is not a god and not a demon. I went close enough to listen. The Choir is people.

Every voice in it was once someone. Someone taken, someone who walked into the water on a Lost Day and did not come home. I heard a fisherman counting nets. I heard a child asking for her mother. I heard my own teacher, dead forty years, humming the tune she used to tune bells by.

The bell they ring is not a call to worship. It is a mouth. It opens on the third night, and whatever answers it is swallowed, and joins the song.

Notebook V: On the Crown

Corvin Hale

Maelis cast the Bell Crown from the Founding Bell's bronze, and the bronze remembers what it was made for.

The crown does not give power. It gives an audience. Whoever wears it, the Choir hears, and whoever the Choir hears, it obeys. A king in that crown could tell the Choir to swallow an army, and it would.

But the Choir is hungry, and it does not stop being hungry because a king is wearing a crown. It simply starts asking him what to eat.

Notebook VI: The Descent

Corvin Hale

I must write down what happened that night before they make me forget it. Quill will write that the King struck a bargain. Quill was not there.

We did not bargain. There is nothing down there to bargain with. We walked the drowned road to the bottom of the Hollow, and on a throne of wet stone sat a thing in the Bell Crown that had once been Queen Maelis. She had been down there four hundred years. She was very small and very hungry.

Oswin killed her. It took a long time. Then he took the crown off her head and put it on his own, and the Choir knelt to him. He told them to eat the Grey Host. And they did, every man, in the space of one bell. That was the miracle.

Notebook VII: On the Lost

Corvin Hale

When the Choir takes someone, something must fill the hole, or the family will come looking, and looking is dangerous. So the Hollow sends back a shape.

The shape knows everything the person knew. It is almost right. But it wears the body the way you would wear another man's glove, and it gets the hands wrong: it favors the wrong one. It does not like bells, because a bell calls it home. And when it believes itself alone, it turns and faces the wall, toward wherever the Hollow is seeping in nearest. It is always a little damp.

I have met six. They were all very polite. One of them asked me, sadly, if I knew where she had gone.

Notebook VIII: On Thin Places

Corvin Hale

The Crack in the Deep will not stay where it is. A door like that drifts toward warmth, and sooner or later it will slide to whichever thin place lies nearest the brightest keep in the land. There are seven thin places I know of.

THE DROWNED CHAPEL, under the sea at Gull's Rest. THE BELLFOUNDERS' MINE in Frostmarch, where Maelis dug her bronze. KING'S BARROW in the Vale, under the royal mound. THE SALTGLASS GROTTO, in the Emberwaste salt flats.

FROSTVEIN HOLLOW, an ice cave in the north. THE SUNKEN QUARRY, the flooded pit west of Millbrook. THE WITCHROOT CAVES, under Blackfen. Whoever finds the door again: it will look like a crack in a cave wall, nothing more, until you are close enough to hear it breathing.

Notebook IX: The Hunger

Corvin Hale

It is a year since the war. The King wears the crown day and night. He has started to hear them as I do.

Today he asked me, quite gently, whether the princess's voice would sound well in a choir. Then he looked at me, and he was himself again, and he wept.

He knows. The crown is not on his head any more. He is on the crown's. He wants to go back down before he says it out loud to someone who will obey.

Notebook X: The Last Page

Corvin Hale

They will burn me tomorrow for refusing to forget him. Let them. I would rather be ash than a liar.

Whoever reads this, understand the shape of it: the crown passes by killing. Whoever kills the one below becomes the one below, in time. Maelis did. Oswin will. You will, if you go down there with a sword and nothing else.

Unless. Maelis cast the bell first and the crown second. The bell is older. If you learn the name of the people she rang it to, and ring the Founding Bell backward with that name, the crown might come off clean. I have no time to test it. Someone must. Someone must keep the door until

COLLECTION IV

The Surveyor's Field Notes

Brother Fennick found where the Gate wandered to, and hid the answer across six notebooks.

1. Field Notes I: Water
2. Field Notes II: Bells
3. Field Notes III: Hands
4. Field Notes IV: Cold
5. Field Notes V: Salt
6. Field Notes VI: Roots
7. Fennick's Last Report

Field Notes I: Water

Brother Ide Fennick, Surveyor of the Gate

The Grandmaster has sent me to find where the Gate has wandered. I have found it. I will not write where. If these notes fall into the wrong hands I will not hand them the door. Instead I write in six books one thing I saw there, so a patient reader can follow, and an impatient one cannot.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

First book done. My boots are still wet from the last site, or dry, depending on which you are asking about, and I will not tell you which.

Field Notes II: Bells

Brother Ide Fennick

The second thing I saw. Remember, Brother, that I visited all seven places, and wrote about one.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

I am told the bells used to be rung to keep the Hollow quiet. I wonder now if they did the opposite.

Field Notes III: Hands

Brother Ide Fennick

Third. I have started to hear something when I sleep. Not words. A tune.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

I measured the crack itself: four men tall and narrow as a door. It breathes. I am not being poetic. The air goes in and out of it.

Field Notes IV: Cold

Brother Ide Fennick

Fourth. The tune is louder. I have been humming it without meaning to.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

The Grandmaster's letter came today asking for my report. I will send these notebooks instead, one at a time, by six different roads.

Field Notes V: Salt

Brother Ide Fennick

Fifth. I dreamed I was in a village where everyone faced the walls. I woke up facing the wall of my tent.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

One more book and you will have all I can give you. Rule out what cannot be true. What is left is the door.

Field Notes VI: Roots

Brother Ide Fennick

Sixth and last. My left hand writes better than my right now. I do not remember learning that.

This page is different in every world.
Find the notebook, and read your own.

That is everything. I have written down six things that are true of the door, and nothing that is true of the other six places. Find the one place where all six are true at once.

Fennick's Last Report

Brother Ide Fennick (written with the wrong hand)

Grandmaster. I have sent you six notebooks by six roads. I hope at least one arrived. I am going back to the door. I need to hear the end of the tune.

If you are not the Grandmaster, and you have all six: go to your Library and name the place. Do not go there first. If you name it wrong you will spend days digging at the wrong cave while it laughs at you.

And when you stand in front of it, do not answer the voice that asks for his daughter.

COLLECTION V

The Lighthouse Letters

Three hundred years of letters from a lighthouse keeper to his drowned wife, in their private cipher.

1. Letter to Annet (the first)
2. Letter to Annet (the second)
3. Letter to Annet (the third)
4. Letter to Annet (the fourth)
5. Letter to Annet (the fifth)
6. Letter to Annet (the sixth)
7. Letter to Annet (the seventh)
8. Letter to Annet (the last)

Letter to Annet (the first)

Elias Marrow, Keeper of the Light at Gull's Rest

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

My Annet. It has been a week. Everyone says I should stop writing to you, so I am writing to you to tell you that.

The night the sea went out you ran down to the strand with half the village to see the seabed. The Grey Host's ships were lying on the sand like dead whales. You waved to me up in the lamp room. And then the sea came back all at once, and I could not see your lantern any more.

I keep the lamp lit every night so you can find the shore. Come home.

Letter to Annet (the second)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. A year. The lamp has not gone out once.

I hear singing on the third night now, very faint, coming up through the water. Hundreds of voices. One of them is yours. I would know it anywhere, you always sang a little sharp.

The new priest says it is the wind in the rocks. The new priest has not been married.

Letter to Annet (the third)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. I have been watching the tides as if they were your face.

Once a month, on the night the moon is dark, the sea goes out further than it ever does otherwise, almost as far as it did the night you went. When it does, the tower of the old chapel of Saint Brannoc shows above the water, and I can see the chapel door.

The door is open. It was not open before.

Letter to Annet (the fourth)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. Men came from the new Order with a book and wrote in the parish register that you died of a fever in the spring.

You did not die of a fever. You went down to the strand on the night the sea went out, the night the war ended, and the sea took you. I told them so. They said it would be better for everyone if it was a fever.

I scratched it out after they left. They wrote it in again. I have stopped going to the chapel.

Letter to Annet (the fifth)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. There is a thing I saw the morning after you went, and I have told no one.

A man walked up out of the sea, near dawn, as the bells were still shaking. He was soaked to the bone and wore a crown, and he did not shiver at all. He asked me the way to Crownhold, very politely. He was holding his sword in his left hand.

I pointed the way and he went. I think I have seen his face on coins. I think I am not supposed to say so.

Letter to Annet (the sixth)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. You came to the window last night.

You were standing on the water under the lamp room, in your wedding dress, and your hair was full of weed, and you were smiling. You said: 'Elias, stop lighting the lamp. It is how they find the shore.'

I did not stop. I cannot stop. If I stop, you will not find me.

Letter to Annet (the seventh)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. I worked out where you are.

Chapel of Saint Brannoc, under the sea. Go in by the open door. Third pew from the drowned altar. Under the floor stone carved with a gull. That is where the water is coldest, and where the singing is loudest. That is where you are.

I will go when the moon is dark and the sea goes out.

Letter to Annet (the last)

Elias Marrow

DECIPHERED WITH THE BRASS WHEEL

Annet. I am going down to you tonight. I have left the lamp lit.

If anyone finds this: I have been keeping this light for three hundred years, and I am tired, and I do not think I have aged a day. I think I may have gone down with her that night and only my habit came back up.

Do not put the lamp out until she is free. Free her first. Then put it out. Then let me go.

COLLECTION VI

Hollow Scripture

Hymns of the Hollow Choir, written backward. Reading them is not good for you.

1. Hymn of the Held Ground
2. The Toll
3. Canticle of the Lantern Keeps
4. Psalm of the Wrong Hand
5. Litany of the Crowned
6. The Mercy of the Bell
7. The Name We Were
8. Hymn for the Coming Crown

Hymn of the Held Ground

The Hollow Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

Sing of the wall that does not fall. Sing of the banner that does not move. Sing of the ones who will not leave. They are warm, they are warm, they are warm.

We were warm once. We held ground once. We remember holding. We do not remember our hands.

Every keep is a lantern. Every lantern is a meal. Every meal is a voice for the song.

The Toll

The Hollow Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

One night we sleep. One night we wake. One night we toll.

On the third night the bell opens and we call. We call to the angry and the empty. We call to the dead who are still walking and the living who are already dead. They hear. They march. They do not know why.

They are not ours. They are only answering. We are the bell. They are the echo.

Canticle of the Lantern Keeps

The Hollow Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

We see you. We see your walls go up. We see your banner. We see the people you bring inside. Brighter. Brighter. Brighter.

When you win, you burn brighter still. We are grateful. We send more.

Little lantern, little keep, you do not know that every stone you lay is a word in our song.

Psalm of the Wrong Hand

The Hollow Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

We send back the shape so no one will come looking.
The shape knows the name. The shape knows the bread.
The shape knows the way to the bed.

But the shape wears the body badly. Its good hand is your wrong hand. Its door is your wall. Its silence is your bell.
And it never quite dries.

Do not ring for the shape. If you ring, it comes home. If it comes home, it brings company.

Litany of the Crowned

The Hollow Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

Hear the names of those who wore the bell. Maelis, who rang us down. Oswin, who killed her and wears us still.

And the third name is not yet sung. The third name is coming. We hear its walls going up. We hear it winning.

Every one who ends the one below becomes the one below. This is the song. This has always been the song.

The Mercy of the Bell

The Hollow Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

Do not be afraid of the bell. The bell is mercy. The bell gathers the lost and brings them home.

No one is cold in the song. No one is alone in the song. No one is forgotten in the song, because no one is anyone in the song.

Come down. Come home. It is warm under the water.

The Name We Were

The Hollow Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

Before the bell we had a name. Before the bell we had a land. The land was Hallowmere, and we were its people.

A queen came out of the marsh with a bell. She said: give me the land and you may sleep. She rang. We slept. We woke under the water. She built Aldmere on our silence.

Say our name and we remember our hands. Ring the bell backward and say our name and we remember everything. Hallowmere. Hallowmere. Do you remember us?

Hymn for the Coming Crown

The Hollow Choir

WRITTEN RIGHT TO LEFT; SET DOWN HERE PLAINLY

A lantern brighter than the rest. A shard of the bell breaks loose to find it. A hand that takes it hears us. A hand that gives it away is watched by those who shut the door.

Either way, little lantern, you are coming down to us. Either way the road ends at the throne.

We will sing your name when you arrive. We are learning it already.

COLLECTION VII

Testimonies of the Lost Days

Statements, notices and confessions from ordinary people. Some of them are lying, and one is not a person.

1. Statement of Reeve Anselm Tock
2. What Happened to Tobin
3. Notice to the People of Millbrook
4. Grandmother Ashby's Account
5. Report of Sir Gerrit the Pale
6. Parish Register of Gull's Rest
7. Town Record of Sunscar
8. Testimony of Old Mag
9. Statement of a Returned Woman
10. What the Farmer Heard

Statement of Reeve Anselm Tock

Anselm Tock, Reeve of Millbrook

I, Anselm Tock, Reeve of Millbrook, make this statement freely. On the night of the first toll after the war, I heard the bell beneath the well. It began at seventeen minutes past three.

I stopped every clock in Millbrook at that minute. If the minute never ends, the toll never finishes, and the bell never finishes opening. That is my reasoning. I stand by it.

There are six clocks in Millbrook. Only one of them is the clock I stopped first, and that is the one that matters. The others I set to match. Some of them have drifted since. Some of the villagers will lie to you about which is which, because they do not want the night to end. They are afraid of what the morning will show them.

What Happened to Tobin

Wren Ashby, aged nine (now Sister Wren)

My brother Tobin went out to the well on the third night and did not come back till morning. Mam said he was just tired.

He is not just tired. He eats with his left hand now. He used to sing in the chapel and now he will not go in when the bell rings. At night I woke up and he was standing in the corner facing the wall and humming.

I asked him what he was humming. He turned round and smiled at me and said 'the way home'. He smiled with the wrong side of his mouth.

Notice to the People of Millbrook

The Reeve's Office (after Tock)

BY ORDER OF THE REEVE. Persons who go missing for a night and come home are NOT to be troubled. They are the same people as before. They are only tired.

There is no cause for alarm. Tales of 'wrong hands' and 'humming' are idle talk, and anyone spreading them will be fined two silver.

Ring no bells after dark. This is for the comfort of the tired, and for no other reason.

Grandmother Ashby's Account

Hild Ashby of Hollowfast, as told to her granddaughter Sigrun

Half the village walked out onto the lake that night. Not running, not afraid. Walking, in their nightclothes, in a line, humming.

I followed their footprints in the morning. They go out to the middle of the lake, all of them together, and they stop. No hole in the ice. No bodies. Just footprints that stop.

Carved on the shrine by the lake is a full moon. My grandmother always said: 'it is the other one you want, Hild.' I never knew what she meant.

Report of Sir Gerrit the Pale

Sir Gerrit, Master of Hounds of the Ashen Gate

Grandmaster: I have run down eleven of the mage's twelve students. The twelfth fled onto the Hollowfast lake with a satchel of books.

She went to the shrine and waited. There was no moon in the sky that night, but when I looked down at the ice there was a moon in it, full and white. Then the ice opened like a door, and she went down into it, and it closed.

I mean to wait for it to open again and follow her. If I do not report again, assume I have.

Parish Register of Gull's Rest

The Chapel of Gull's Rest

Deaths this spring: Joss Penrow, fisherman, drowned. Mary Kettle, of age. Annet Marrow, wife of Elias the lamp-keeper, of a fever.

(The entry for Annet Marrow has been scratched out, and written in again in a different hand, and scratched out again, and written in again. The last time it was written, someone pressed so hard the nib went through the page.)

Deaths this summer: none. The sea has been very calm.

Town Record of Sunscar

The Wardens of Sunscar

In the year after the war, the faces of all the statues in Sunscar were worn away by the desert wind, in a single summer. This is well known and not remarkable.

The fragments were swept up and the statues left as they are, as a lesson in the patience of the desert.

Visitors are asked not to search for the fragments. There are no fragments. The wind took them.

Testimony of Old Mag

Magda Venn of Mirelight

My name is Magda Venn. I am three hundred and eleven years old. I was the mage Corvin's last apprentice, and I was twelve when they burned him.

I ran into the swamp. The Order sent a man with hounds after Corvin's students. He got the others. He did not get me, because the swamp hid me, and something under the swamp kept me. I do not age. I do not want to know why.

The people of Mirelight think I am a mad old woman who claims to be three hundred. They are half right.

Statement of a Returned Woman

Unsigned (the ink is still wet, and always will be)

I am Dora Penrow. I went to the well. I came back. I am Dora Penrow.

I know the name of the dog and the name of the baby and where the bread is kept. I know all of it. Why does the dog not know me.

Sometimes I stand facing the wall because that is where the door is. The door is not there. I wait anyway. Someone is coming to take me home.

What the Farmer Heard

Hobb Carrow, farmer (recent)

Something fell out of the sky three nights ago, after the raiders were beaten off at the new keep up the hill. A pale light, humming. It landed in my turnips.

It whispered names. None I know. Tamsin Reed. Aldo Kettle. Little Jory Fenn. I asked around. Nobody by those names lives anywhere near. I keep hearing them anyway.

A knight came in the morning asking for it. By then it was gone. He looked frightened. Knights should not look frightened.

COLLECTION VIII

The Fallen

The last words of the great enemies of the land, taken from them when they fell.

1. The Reeve's Ledger
2. The Huntsman's Tally
3. Annet's Prayer
4. The Seneschal's Confession
5. The Mother's Lullaby
6. Vorlund's Oath
7. Oswin's Final Testament

The Reeve's Ledger

Anselm Tock, the Clockwork Reeve

Day 1 of the minute. The clocks are stopped. The bell is quiet. It worked.

Day 40 of the minute. The bell is not quiet. It is only very slow. Every year the minute moves a hair. I have begun replacing my own parts with clockwork, so I can stay awake to hold it.

Day 109,500 of the minute. I am mostly gears now. When someone finally stops me, the minute will end, the bell will finish its stroke, and the well will open. I am sorry. I held it as long as I could.

The Huntsman's Tally

Sir Gerrit, the Pale Huntsman

Eleven notches for eleven students. The twelfth I followed down through the ice.

Below the ice there is a town. It is not Hollowfast. It is no town of ours at all: black water in the streets, leaning towers, a sky with its own moon. And the half of Hollowfast who walked out onto the lake are standing in its square, facing a wall, humming. The twelfth student was with them. She smiled at me. Then the hounds turned on me.

I have been hunting my way back up ever since. I do not remember what I was hunting when I started.

Annet's Prayer

Annet Marrow, the Drowned Bride

Saint Brannoc, who loved the sea, let him put the lamp out.

Every night he lights it, and every night the Choir sees the shore by it, and sends something up the beach. He thinks he is guiding me home. He is guiding them.

I am not angry with him. I was never angry with him. Tell him to put it out, and then tell him I am waiting, and then let him come.

The Seneschal's Confession

Lord Hadrian Sorrel, the Ash Seneschal

It was not the wind. I did it. The Regent asked the Order to remove her father's face from every statue in Aldmere, and I asked to do Sunscar myself, because I had served him, and I wanted the last hands on his face to be gentle ones.

I took the faces off one by one with a mason's chisel. I scattered the fragments so they could not be put back. When I finished the last one, I put my hand to my own face and it was smooth.

Whoever rebuilds his face, rebuild mine too, if you can. I would like to be able to weep for him.

The Mother's Lullaby

The Mother of Changelings

Hush, hush, I make you a shape. A shape for the bed you left. A shape for the door you went out of. A shape so no one comes looking.

I am not cruel. I am tidy. The Choir takes and I fill the hole. If I did not, they would come down after you with torches and bells, and then the Choir would have them too.

Every changeling is my child. Every child is a hole with a shape in it. Hush now. Face the wall. That is where the door is.

Vorlund's Oath

Vorlund, last Thane of the Grey Host, the Warlord King

I was Thane of the Ice Isles. I led the Grey Host. Our priests heard a bell under the ice and told us that whoever held Aldmere's bells would hold the world, so we came for them.

At Bellhollow the bell answered. My army was swallowed in one stroke. I was swallowed too, and the Choir chewed on me for a while, and spat me back up with a splinter of the crown in my brow so they could hear through me.

Every third night it tells me where to march. I have led your enemies for three hundred years. I have never once chosen where to go. Kill me, and see if it lets me stay dead.

Oswin's Final Testament

Oswin the Last, King of Aldmere

I am still here. I have always been here. My daughter shut the door and I thanked her for it.

I killed Maelis and took her crown, and for one night I was the greatest king who ever lived. Then the crown began asking me what to eat. I came down here so that the answer would not be my own city. I have spent three hundred years telling it no, and lately I have begun to say yes. Your keeps are so bright.

If you kill me, you will wear it. Corvin was right about the other way: learn the name of the people Maelis drowned, ring her bell backward, and say it. The crown will come off clean, and the Choir will remember its hands, and you will rule without the hunger. I never found the name. Tell Edda I am sorry. Tell her the door was right.



Here the Library ends.

SAY THEIR NAME.